GRE Sentence Equivalence Drill Pack

The Synonym-Pair Protocol, Sentence Completion Logic, Context Verification & Trap Avoidance

1. The Fundamental Architecture of Sentence Equivalence

Sentence Equivalence (SE) requires selecting TWO choices from a list of 6 that create coherent sentences with identical meanings.

SE Dimension	Operational Requirement	Critical Nuance to Remember
Number of Choices	Exactly 6 answer choices provided per question	You must select exactly TWO choices; partial credit is never awarded
Dual Criterion for Correctness	1) The two words must produce identical sentence meanings, AND 2) They must fit the specific context	Two perfect synonyms that do not fit the sentence logic are WRONG!
Synonym Pairing Reality	Typically, the 6 choices contain 2 (or sometimes 3) pairs of related words	Identifying the pairs immediately narrows 6 choices down to 2 or 3 options
Target Pacing	Complete each Sentence Equivalence question in 45 to 60 seconds	Fastest verbal question type; saves time for Reading Comprehension

Golden Rule: Two words do not need to be strict dictionary synonyms; they must produce equivalent meaning in THIS sentence.

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2. The 4-Step Sentence Equivalence Execution Plan

Follow this exact 4-step sequence on every Sentence Equivalence question.

Step Number	Action Protocol	Methodology	Key Objective
Step 1: Read Sentence for Logic	Read prompt; identify structural roadmaps (contrast vs support)	Ignore answer choices initially	Determine the intended direction and tone of the sentence
Step 2: Pre-phrase the Blank	State in your own words what word belongs in the blank	Use simple, everyday English	Prevents being lured by high-sounding distractor words
Step 3: Scan Choices for Synonym Pairs	Group the 6 options into pairs of similar meaning	Eliminate standalone words that have no matching pair	Reduces 6 individual choices to 2 or 3 viable pairs
Step 4: Test Surviving Pairs in Sentence	Plug each pair into the sentence to verify coherence	Read the complete sentence for natural fit	Confirm both sentences communicate the exact same idea

Time-Saver: If a word in the choices has no synonym pair among the other 5 options, it is almost always incorrect.

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3. Top 3 Traps in Sentence Equivalence

Avoid the classic traps engineered by ETS question writers.

- Trap 1: The "False Friends" Pair. Two words that are perfect synonyms in English, but completely contradict the sentence clue.
- Trap 2: The "Near-Synonym" Trap. Words that share a general theme (e.g. "frugal" vs "miserly") but introduce different emotional tones.
- Trap 3: Over-Focusing on Vocabulary Instead of Clues. If you cannot define a word, eliminate the words you KNOW are wrong to isolate the remaining pair.
- Trap 4: Selecting Only One Choice. Remember to click BOTH checkmarks before confirming and moving to the next question.